

RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TEST → FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS → BUDDHISM → JAINISM, MĪMĀMSĀ AND SĀMĀKHYA → CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE → NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g9 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TEST

DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TESTCAN RELIGION EXIST WITHOUT A CREATOR GOD?RELIGION MAY ORGANISEULTIMATE CONCERNSACRED VALUEMORAL DISCIPLINE WORLDVIEWTHEISM IS SUFFICIENT FOR MANY RELIGIONS, NOT CONCEPTUALLY NECESSARY

ATHEISTIC; SILENCE, IRRELEVANCE AND DENIAL ARE DIFFERENT POSITIONS.

religion may organise

ultimate concern

sacred value

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

01

STAGE 01

FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS

FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONSDENIES THAT GOD EXISTSUSPENDS JUDGEMENT BECAUSE KNOWLEDGE/EVIDENCE IS INSUFFICIENTGOD IS ABSENT OR NON-CENTRAL TO THE PATHHOLDS GOD-BELIEF HARMFUL OR FALSE IN A STRONGER EVALUATIVE

"GOD" MUST BE MADE MEANINGFUL BEFORE EXISTENCE IS DEBATEDLIFE ORGANISED WITHOUT REFERENCE TO GOD KEEP EPISTEMIC SUSPENSION

ATHEISM: denies that God exists

AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

NON-THEISM: God is absent or non-central to the path

ANTI-THEISM: holds God-belief harmful or false in a stronger evaluative sense

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

02

STAGE 02

BUDDHISM

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHSDDEPENDENT ORIGATIONEIGHTFOLD PATHNIRVĀNA NO ETERNAL CREATOR IS NEEDED; SUFFERING HAS CONDITIONEDBUDDHA REJECTS SPECULATIVE QUESTIONS WHEN THEY DO NOT CONDUCEKARMA/ORDER FUNCTIONS LIKE HIDDEN PROVIDENCE REPLY

CAUSAL-MORAL REGULARITY IS IMPERSONAL; NO OMNIPOTENT ALLOCATOR OR CREATOR

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is

suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent

Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of dukkha objection: karma/order

no omnipotent allocator or creator follows.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Dependent origination and karma (action and moral causation) make a creator explanatorily unnecessary, while ethics, meditation, community and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) preserve a fully religious form of life.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dependent origination and karma (action and moral causation) make a creator explanatorily unnecessary, while ethics, meditation, community and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) preserve a fully religious form of life.

03

STAGE 03

JAINISM, MĪMĀMSĀ AND SĀMĀKHYA

JAINISM, MĪMĀMSĀ AND SĀMĀKHYAETERNAL JĪVA/AJĪVA; KARMIC MATTER; TĪRTHANKARA TEACHES, NOT CREATESAUTHORLESS ETERNAL VEDA; RITUAL ACTION GENERATES APŪRVĀ; NO DIVINEPRAKṚTI EVOLVES FOR PLURAL PURUṢAS; UNCONSCIOUS TELEOLOGY WITHOUT CREATOR

IF GOD IS PERFECT, WHY CREATE? IF EMBODIED, WHOJAINISM RETAINS WORSHIPFUL EXEMPLARS; MĪMĀMSĀ CENTRES DHARMA/RITUALSĀMĀKHYA CENTRES DISCRIMINATIVE METAPHYSICS AND KĀIVALYA

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
JAINISM: eternal jīva/ajīva; karmic matter; tīrthankara teaches, not creates	unconscious teleology without creator shared anti-creator pressure: if God is perfect, why create?	Sāṃkhya centres discriminative metaphysics and kaivalya.
MĪMĀMSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrvā; no divine author needed	if embodied, who made body?	
SĀMĀKHYA: prakṛti evolves for plural puruṣas	distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual	

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

EVALUATION / TRAP

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

04

STAGE 04

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASECĀRVĀKA DENIES GOD, AFTERLIFE, KARMA, VEDIC AUTHORITY AND MOKṢA DOES IT COUNT AS RELIGION?DOCTRINAL-HISTORICAL MEMBER OF INDIAN PHILOSOPHICAL DEBATEYES SACRED/TRANSCENDENT/SOTERIOLOGICAL PRACTICE IN ROBUST SENSE

LARGELY NO LIMIT CASE SHOWS THAT "PHILOSOPHY WITHOUT GOD"BUDDHISM/JAINISM BETTER PRESERVE RITUAL, COMMUNITY AND LIBERATION FUNCTIONS.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

05

STAGE 05

NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISM

NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISMGOD IS DEADCOLLAPSE OF THE CHRISTIAN-METAPHYSICAL VALUE HORIZON DANGERNIHILISM, HERD MORALITY EXPOSED, NO TRANSCENDENT GUARANTOR TASKREVALUATION OF VALUESLIFE-AFFIRMATION NOT A SIMPLE EMPIRICAL PROOF THAT NO DEITY

SELF-CREATED VALUES RISK ARBITRARINESS OR DOMINATION REPLYGENEALOGY TESTS INHERITED VALUES; AFFIRMATIVE CREATION ACCEPTS RESPONSIBILITY

"GOD IS DEAD" = collapse of the Christian-metaphysical value horizon danger: nihilism, herd morality exposed

affirmative creation accepts responsibility

POST-THEISM asks what religious depth survives after classical supernatural belief.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Nietzsche's 'death of God' is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nietzsche's 'death of God' is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

06

STAGE 06

NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISM

NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISMRELIGIOUS NATURALISMNATURE IS ULTIMATE; AWE, GRATITUDE, RITUAL AND ETHICS WITHOUTPARTICIPATE IN GOD-LANGUAGE/PRACTICE WITHOUT LITERAL ONTOLOGICAL ASSENTSEA OF FAITHRELIGIOUS SYMBOLS SHAPE LIFE RATHER THAN REPORT A TRANSCENDENT

WORSHIP WITHOUT REAL OBJECT IS MAKE-BELIEVE; PRAYER LOSES ADDRESSSYMBOLS AND COMMUNAL NARRATIVES CAN DISCLOSE VALUE AND TRANSFORM

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: nature is ultimate; awe, gratitude, ritual and ethics without supernaturalism

FICTIONALISM: participate in God-language/practice without literal ontological assent

SEA OF FAITH / non-realism: religious symbols shape life rather than report a transcendent entity

prayer loses address

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

07

STAGE 07

PYQ AND QUALIFIED VERDICT

PYQ AND QUALIFIED VERDICTDEFINE RELIGION BY CLUSTERED FEATURESDISTINGUISH FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONSDEMONSTRATE BUDDHISM/JAINISM/MĪMĀMSĀ/SĀMĀKHYAUSE CĀRVĀKA BOUNDARYOBJECTION ON TRUTH/OBJECTVERDICT BY CRITERION CREATOR-BELIEF NECESSARY? NO

ULTIMATE CONCERN/RITUAL/TRANSFORMATION POSSIBLE? YES PERSONAL WORSHIP AND PROVIDENCE PRESERVED?

DEFINE religion by clustered features → distinguish four negative positions

demonstrate Buddhism/Jainism/Mīmāṃsā/Sāṃkhya → use Cārvāka boundary

Nietzsche/post-theism → naturalism/fictionalism → objection on truth/object

VERDICT BY CRITERION creator-belief necessary? NO

ultimate concern/ritual/transformation possible? YES personal worship and providence preserved? often NO

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT BY CRITERION creator-belief necessary? NO | ultimate concern/ritual/transformation possible? YES personal worship and providence preserved? often NO

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT BY CRITERION creator-belief necessary? NO | ultimate concern/ritual/transformation possible? YES personal worship and providence preserved? often NO.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENTADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]DOCTRINE STATEMENTSUBSTANTIVE DEFINITIONS IDENTIFY RELIGION BY REFERENCE TO GODS ORFUNCTIONAL DEFINITIONS IDENTIFY ORIENTATION, PRACTICE, COMMUNITY, MEANING OR LIBERATION.

IF CREATOR-BELIEF IS MADE NECESSARY BY DEFINITION, BUDDHISM IS A MULTIDIMENSIONAL ACCOUNT BETTER CAPTURES DOCTRINE, RITUAL, ETHICS, EXPERIENCEPRESUPPOSITION: CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

ADVANCED OBJECTION

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.